

Smartphones Vs Camera

With the advent of smartphones, the camera market seems to be taking a backseat according to results of the latest NPD Group survey: <http://bit.ly/v8sQvK>



Hollywood goes gaga

More than 200 of Sony's F65 4K digital cinematography cameras have been pre-ordered in the U.S., according to a Sony exec

HOW WE TESTED

We evaluated the cameras based on their ergonomics. This is a very important aspect which is always overlooked for the more fancy features. In-hand feel of the camera and accessibility of buttons was scored, with cameras having a very intuitive one hand operation scoring over those which require you to use both hands for operation. We also gave more points to those cameras that had buttons with great feedback and had zoom dials which were quiet and offered a jerk-free zooming mechanism.

The features listing was given a 30 per cent weightage as with point and shoots it is imminent to be a feature rich camera. Things such as GPS, Panorama, HD video recording, image stabilisation, various flash modes, etc. got a definite advantage over cameras that did not have these features. Connectivity options were looked at and cameras sporting PictBridge support gained extra points.

Performance testing

We divided the performance testing across various aspects of the camera such as High ISO test, Sharpness and Detail test, Flash tests, Macro test, Indoor and outdoor HD video recording test, Low light test, zoom test, among others.

High ISO Test: In the high ISO test, we shot a standard scene having a healthy mix of colours, textures, detailed objects, etc., in a group. This scene was lit under our studio lights



and keeping the cameras in Aperture Priority mode at f/4.0, 0 EV, evaluative metering, we shot the scene at ISO 200, 400, 800, 1600, 3200 and 6400. All the outputs were scored out of 10 based on their clarity and resistance to noise at various ISO levels.

Low Light Test: For the low light test, we kept an object (a toy car) in a badly lit room. Keeping the camera on a tripod, we tested the camera's low light modes. We also tested the camera's performance at high ISO and how detailed the image was rendered.



HD Video recording (Indoor): We shot this scene in our office as indoors most cameras tend to introduce noise. We were looking for outputs which had minimal noise and also how well the zooming functioned. Cameras which were able to keep the faces in focus despite zooming got a higher score.

HD Video recording (Outdoor): For this we shot a series of three videos involving horizontal panning, vertical panning, zooming and checking the camera's ability to resist focus hunting while zooming. This test was carried out in broad daylight at the highest video shooting resolution.

Macro: For the macro tests, we set the cameras in macro mode if the option was present and set ISO 200 to reduce noise to a minimum. For the test shot, we took a close-up of a standard 17" LCD monitor which had been running for at least 4 hours. The distance was maintained at 4cm from the screen. The



aim was to see how well the individual pixels were captured.

Sharpness Test: In this test we took two objects - a PCB and a wall of sewing thread of varying colours. We used evaluative metering, kept the camera at 0EV in Aperture Priority mode at f/4.0 and ISO 400. We scored the images based on how sharp they were, specially how well we were able to see the texture on the threads and how well the minute components such as resistors/capacitors came out in the final image.

Flash Exposure: This test was carried out in total darkness. Each camera was set in full auto mode with flash. We metered off a grey card and evaluated this image to see if the colour was exactly 18% grey as on the grey card. The aim of this test is to check how good the flash is at exposing up a scene. Scoring was based on how close grey card's image was as compared to the actual expected value.

Fill Flash Test: For this test we had a human subject at a distance of 5-6feet from the camera, in a partially lit room. We had the cameras set on Auto mode and flash intensity at standard. We let the camera decide the ISO based on its intelligence and checked the final image for clarity, focus on the faces and how well it was exposed. Cameras which overexposed the subject naturally got a lower score and cameras which were able to show a good amount of detail got an edge over the others, which rendered the background as partially or completely dark.

low light conditions. Also at its maximum zoom, the aperture is still at a respectable f/2.5. Like the S100, it sports a control ring in the front which can be programmed to control ISO or aperture or shutter among

other things. Build quality is very sturdy and it has a good grip thanks to the rubber thumb rest. It sports a 3-inch 610k dot OLED screen. Navigating through the options is quite easy, but one may get overwhelmed

by the number of options on offer. The circular dial beside the screen can scroll as well as act as a fourway d-pad which makes adjusting the aperture, shutter and exposure easy, and also helps in navigating through

the many options. It supports the full manual M mode where the control dial around the lens controls aperture while the scroll dial controls the shutter. The XZ-1 also offers live histogram view along with RAW support.